

ST 01: Introduction to Theology

Teaching Notes, Part 2: Unit I — Discovering Theology (Lectures 1 to 5)

Morning Star Regional Seminary, Barrackpore For the use of the Professor

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These are your notes. Each lecture gives the opening problem, the teaching content, the references, the cross-references to the rest of the course, the illustrations for the board, and a teaching tip with the reading and the reflection prompt.

THE ARC OF UNIT I

Unit I answers the second of the six goals, why do theology, and opens the first, what is theology. It does its work in five steps. Lecture 1 shows that the priest cannot avoid theology, only do it well or badly. Lecture 2 shows that faith itself wants to understand. Lecture 3 asks how God reaches us at all, and answers with revelation. Lecture 4 asks what it means to receive that reaching, and answers with faith. Lecture 5 turns the whole unit toward the person of the student and names theology a vocation, and so it plants the sixth goal, the responsible theologian, on the fifth day. The unit lays the ground on which the four precepts of Lonergan will later build, for a man cannot be attentive, intelligent, reasonable, and responsible in theology until he has first seen why theology is worth his life.

LECTURE 1: Can a priest preach without doing theology?

The opening problem. Put the question to the class and let them defend both sides. Many will say yes, a simple priest with a good heart can preach the Gospel without all this study. Hold the tension, then turn it. Every time a priest opens his mouth in the pulpit, he is interpreting the Word of God for a particular people in a particular hour. That act of interpretation is theology. So the honest answer is that a priest cannot preach without doing theology; he can only preach with good theology or with bad. The course exists so that it will be good.

The teaching content. Begin where the matter is clearest, with what theology is not. Theology is not brainwashing, and it is not an adult catechism, and it is not merely a thorough knowledge of Christian doctrine, though it includes such knowledge. Theology is a living process that moves from information to formation to transformation, and at its centre stands the personal and communal experience of God. The word itself joins *theos*, God, and *logos*, word or study, so theology is discourse on God, the study of God, God-talk. The scholastic tradition gathers its threefold shape in one line: theology is taught by God, teaches of God, and leads to God. It begins in faith experience, it deals with the deepest

questions a human being can raise about life, the world, and God, and it ends not in a full notebook but in a changed life.

It helps to give the students the deepest content of theology at once, so that they sense its weight. Karl Rahner said that the only truly absolute mysteries in Christianity are grace and Christ, that is, the self-communication of God in the depths of human existence, which we call grace, and in history, which we call Christ. M. M. Thomas located the prophetic core of the faith in the claim that God has acted in a unique way in a real historical event, the incarnation, life, death, and resurrection of Jesus, to begin his Kingdom. Theology is the attempt to understand this, and the focus of Christian theology is always Jesus, the Kingdom, and the mission of the Church patterned on the Abba experience of Jesus.

Illustration. Grammar. Imagine a man who says, "I do not bother with grammar, I just speak." But he uses grammar in every sentence he utters; the only question is whether his grammar is correct. Theology is the grammar of preaching and of faith. The priest who says he does not do theology is like that man: he is doing it in every homily, and the only question is whether he is doing it well. A second image, if you have time: the village pump. A man who has memorised the sentence "there is water below" has information. The man who has learned to dig the well and work the pump brings the water up for the whole village. Theology is meant to be the second kind of knowing.

References. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* Ia, q. 1, for theology as a sacred science and for the threefold shape gathered in the axiom *a Deo docetur, Deum docet, et ad Deum ducit*. Karl Rahner, *Foundations of Christian Faith*, for grace and Christ as the two absolute mysteries. M. M. Thomas, for the prophetic core of Christian faith. Pope Francis, *Veritatis Gaudium*, proem, for the restlessness of the heart until it rests in the truth who is Christ.

Cross-references. This lecture opens the first goal, what is theology, which Unit II will answer in full. The list of what theology is not returns at Lecture 10, where you draw the line between theology and heresy. The claim that faith experience is the starting point returns through Unit III, the sources.

For the professor. Open by asking, "Did anyone here do theology this morning?" Most will say no. Then show them that the man who prayed, the man who read a psalm and asked what it meant for him, and the man who decided a moral question before breakfast were all doing theology, whether well or badly. End by setting the aim of the whole course in one sentence: to learn what theology is and how to do it well. Reading: the Manual, pages 1 to 2. Reflection prompt for the journal: "I came to study theology because..."

LECTURE 2: If I already believe, why must I understand?

The opening problem. A pious seminarian may quietly resent this course. He may think, "I already have faith; why must I dissect it? Will all this study not cool my devotion?" Name the fear aloud, because it is honest and many share it. Then answer it: understanding is not the enemy of faith but its fruit. Faith that refuses to understand is not deeper faith; it is a faith afraid of itself.

The teaching content. The classical answer is the phrase of Anselm of Canterbury, *fides quaerens intellectum*, faith seeking understanding, and the order of the words matters. Anselm wrote, "I do not seek to understand in order that I may believe, but I believe in order that I may understand." Faith comes first; it is the door. But once inside, faith naturally seeks to understand the One it has embraced, and that understanding deepens the faith rather than replacing it. Augustine had already taught the same double movement: believe that you may understand, and understand that you may believe. Hold the students in the middle between two errors. Fideism accepts everything God reveals and refuses to let reason examine any of it, and so it silences the mind God gave us. Rationalism rejects everything reason cannot fully grasp, and so it silences faith. Theology walks between them. Faith is not fully rational, for it reaches the One who is greater than our minds, yet it is fully reasonable, for it is no leap into nonsense.

Remind them that the *Proslogion* of Anselm is not a lecture but a prayer; the great argument is set within an address to God, by a man seeking the face of God on his knees. This is the model: understanding sought in prayer, not against it. And recall Aquinas, for whom theology is a science, the orderly understanding of what is believed, with reason as the servant of faith and never its judge.

Illustration. Love seeking knowledge. When a man truly loves a woman, he wants to know everything about her, not because his love is weak but because love by its nature longs to know the beloved more deeply. A husband who said, "I love my wife, so I have no need to know her," would have a strange and shallow love. Faith that refuses to understand God is exactly that strange love. A second image: a child trusts his mother long before he understands her, and that trust is real; but as he grows and comes to understand her, his trust does not weaken, it deepens. Faith seeking understanding is faith growing up.

References. Anselm, *Proslogion*, proem and chapter 1, for *credo ut intelligam*. Augustine, Sermon 43 and the Tractates on the Gospel of John, for "believe that you may understand." Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* Ia, q. 1, articles 1, 5, and 8, for theology as science and for reason in the service of faith. John Paul II, *Fides et Ratio*, for the harmony of faith and reason.

Cross-references. This lecture deepens the first goal, what is theology. The theme of faith and reason returns in Lecture 4, on faith, in Lecture 5, with *Fides et Ratio*, and reaches its historical climax in Lecture 19, where the Scholastic age asks whether faith and reason can live together. The seashore image of Augustine, used in Part 1 for the first goal, belongs here too: the mind never empties the ocean of God.

For the professor. Speak gently to the anxious student. Tell the class that the great saints were great theologians, that Teresa of Avila and Augustine and Thomas prayed more, not less, the more they understood. The cure for a cold theology is not less theology but theology done on the knees. Reading: Anselm, the proem of the *Proslogion*; the Manual, page 1; Ormerod, Chapter 1, pages 3 to 9. Reflection prompt: "One definition of theology I will keep is... because..."

The opening problem. If God is infinite, invisible, and incomprehensible, how can a finite human being know anything of him at all? Is not all our talk of God simply our own imagination dressed up? Pose this honestly, because it is the doubt of the modern world. The answer is the doctrine of revelation: we do not climb up to God; God stoops down to us.

The teaching content. Revelation is the free and gracious self-communication of God to human beings. The Second Vatican Council teaches that in his goodness and wisdom God chose to reveal himself and to make known the hidden purpose of his will, speaking to human beings as friends and inviting them into communion with himself. Stress three things. First, revelation is a gift, not a human achievement; we could never have reasoned our way to the inner life of God. Second, God reveals himself through deeds and words together, having an inner unity: in creation he shows himself as the author of life, in the Exodus as the liberator, in the paschal mystery as the lover, in the Church as the God of a new people. Third, revelation is personal; God does not merely send information about himself, he gives himself.

Jesus Christ is the fullness and the mediator of revelation. As the Letter to the Hebrews says, in many and various ways God spoke of old through the prophets, but in these last days he has spoken to us by a Son. After Christ no new public revelation is to be expected before his glorious return, yet this does not mean God has fallen silent, for the Council affirms that he remains present and active in other cultures and religions. The centre of all that is revealed is the Trinity, the disclosure of God as Father, Son, and Spirit, heard already in the prayer of Jesus, "Abba, Father." And revelation, though freely given, becomes complete only when it is received; the human response of faith belongs to it, which is the matter of the next lecture.

A word on natural knowledge of God will help the bright student. The First Vatican Council teaches that God can be known with certainty by the natural light of human reason from the things he has made, for the creation reflects the rays of his perfection. This is why we can speak of God at all, and why we must speak analogically, calling him Father and Shepherd, since these words point truly toward him without ever containing him.

Illustration. The parent and the infant. How does a mother communicate with a baby who cannot yet understand a single word? Not by lectures but by presence, touch, food, and a smiling face; she gets down to the level of the child. God reveals himself in the same way, first by deeds and presence and only then by words, and in the incarnation he gets all the way down onto the floor of our world. A second image, drawn from Scripture: the burning bush. God reaches Moses not with a treatise but with a strange fire that makes him "turn aside and look." Revelation often comes first as wonder, as the strange thing that stops us, what Rudolf Otto called the mystery that is at once tremendous and fascinating.

References. *Dei Verbum* 2 to 6, for revelation in deeds and words and for its reception in faith; *Dei Verbum* 4, for Christ as the fullness of revelation. Hebrews 1:1 to 2, in the Revised Standard Version, Catholic Edition. Catechism of the Catholic Church 65 to 66, for no new public revelation. First Vatican Council, *Dei Filius*, with Romans 1:20, for the natural

knowledge of God. Karl Rahner, for revelation as the self-communication of God. Rudolf Otto, *The Idea of the Holy*, for the holy as *mysterium tremendum et fascinans*.

Cross-references. Revelation is one of the two foundations of theology and is inseparable from faith, the matter of Lecture 4. The sources through which revelation reaches us, Scripture and Tradition, are taught in Unit III, Lectures 12 and 13. The analogical language of God deepens the account of how we can speak of him at all.

For the professor. Keep returning to the word gift. The students must not leave thinking revelation is something the Church possesses and controls; it is something the Church receives on her knees. Reading: *Dei Verbum*, Chapter 1, sections 2 to 6; the Manual, pages 11 to 12. Reflection prompt: "A moment in regency when God seemed to be communicating with me was..."

LECTURE 4: Is faith a leap in the dark or a way of seeing?

The opening problem. The modern caricature says that faith is believing without evidence, a leap in the dark, the surrender of the mind. Put the caricature on the board honestly, then take it apart. Faith is not blindness; it is a way of seeing. It reaches further than reason can prove, yet it is not a leap into nothing; it is a leap into the arms of One we have come to trust.

The teaching content. Faith is not merely the assent of the mind to a list of truths, though it includes such assent. The Letter to the Hebrews calls it the assurance of things hoped for and the conviction of things not seen, a way of being certain of the unseen. Scripture shows faith again and again as a personal encounter that changes the whole person: Moses at the bush, the Samaritan woman at the well, the disciples at the Transfiguration and on the road to Emmaus. For the Christian, this encounter is with Jesus Christ, and faith is the total response and self-gift of the whole person to God as he is revealed in Christ. Distinguish for the students the two faces of faith: the act of believing, the trust by which we say yes, which the tradition calls *fides qua*, and the content believed, the truths we hold, which it calls *fides quae*. Living faith holds both; trust without content is vague, and content without trust is dead.

Set faith and reason side by side once more. They are, in the image of John Paul II, like two wings on which the human spirit rises to truth. Faith is not against reason; it is not fully rational, since it reaches the One greater than our minds, yet it is fully reasonable. Trace faith through the Scriptures: in the Old Testament Abraham is the father of all who believe, and faith there rests on the fidelity of God to his covenant; in the New Testament faith is the acceptance of Jesus and his message, and its models are Mary, Joseph, Zachariah, Elizabeth, the disciples, and above all Jesus himself, who entrusted himself to his Abba through every struggle and whose yes to the Father was total and never withdrawn. Our faith is meant to take the shape of his. And faith is at once gift and response: it is the grace of God and the free yes of the human person, the *fiat* of Mary at the Annunciation.

Illustration. Glasses, not a blindfold. Faith does not stop you seeing; it lets you see what was always there but blurred. The two disciples on the road to Emmaus had working eyes the

whole way, yet they did not see the Lord until faith opened them, and then "their eyes were opened and they recognised him." A second image for the leap: the child who jumps from a wall into the arms of a father he knows. The caricature says faith is a leap into the dark; Christian faith is a leap toward Someone whose love you have already tasted, as Abraham leapt toward a God whose fidelity he had known. A third, if it helps a married audience of the future: faith is like trust between spouses, which has no mathematical proof and yet is not irrational, because it rests on a real knowing of the person.

References. Hebrews 11:1 to 3, in the Revised Standard Version, Catholic Edition. Romans 4, for Abraham, the father of those who believe. *Dei Verbum* 5, for the obedience of faith as the response to revelation. John Paul II, *Fides et Ratio*, opening, for faith and reason as two wings. Luke 24:13 to 35, for the opened eyes at Emmaus. The distinction of *fides qua* and *fides quae* is the common teaching of the scholastic tradition.

Cross-references. Faith is the partner of revelation in Lecture 3, and together they are the two foundations of theology. Faith and reason return in Lecture 19, the Scholastic age. That faith is the condition which makes theology possible was already stated in Lecture 1.

For the professor. Help the students see that the opposite of faith is not doubt. A faith with no questions is often a faith that has never been examined. Doubt, honestly carried, can be the growing pain of a deeper faith. What kills faith is not the honest question but the closed heart. Reading: *Fides et Ratio*, sections 1 to 15. Reflection prompt: "A question in regency that faith alone could not answer, but reason helped with, was..."

LECTURE 5: Is theology a job or a calling?

The opening problem. Ask the class plainly: is this course a hoop you must jump through for ordination, a requirement to be survived, or is it a calling? Many seminarians treat theology as a hurdle between them and the altar. The question turns the whole unit toward the person of the student. Theology is a vocation within the vocation, and how a man holds it will shape the kind of priest he becomes. This lecture plants the sixth goal, the responsible theologian, on the fifth day, exactly as the architecture intends.

The teaching content. The theologian is not first a clever person but a believer who thinks. Set before the students the five dimensions of the one who does theology: he is a believer, for theology springs from faith; a thinker, willing to ask hard questions and follow reason honestly; a listener, to Scripture, to Tradition, to the Magisterium, to the *sensus fidelium*, and above all to the poor; a servant, who studies on behalf of the People of God and not for himself; and a prophet, willing to name injustice and speak the truth, as the Gospel demands. The First Letter of Peter gives the charter of the vocation: be ready to give an account of the hope that is in you, with gentleness and reverence, so as to throw light on the great mysteries of life and death, of suffering and evil, of liberation and redemption.

The Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith, in *Donum Veritatis*, calls theology one of the vocations awakened by the Spirit in the Church. The theologian stands as a kind of mediator between the faith handed down and the questions of the present age, owing both

fidelity to the Word entrusted to the Church and the honest freedom proper to searching study. Here you plant the word that the whole course is built toward: responsible. To be a responsible theologian is to be answerable, to hold together obedience and the prophetic duty to question, and to count the cost, for the prophetic dimension has often cost the prophet dearly. Foreshadow the end: on the last day each student will stand and read his own Theology Manifesto, declaring the kind of theologian he commits to becoming. Everything between now and then is preparation for that standing up.

Illustration. The shepherd and the hired hand, from the tenth chapter of John. The hired hand does the work for wages and runs when the wolf comes; the shepherd knows his sheep and lays down his life for them. The man who does theology as a job is the hired hand; the man who does it as a calling is the shepherd, and the difference shows the moment a real wolf, a grieving family, a doubting youth, a hostile official, appears at the door of the parish. A second image, from the motto of this house: the lamp on the lampstand. Theology is not a private cleverness to be hidden under a bushel; it is a light set on a stand to give light to the whole house. A third, if you wish: two musicians, one who plays only for the wage and one who plays for love. The difference is audible in the first bar. A theology done only to pass an examination is lifeless; a theology done as a calling carries the smell of life.

References. 1 Peter 3:15, in the Revised Standard Version, Catholic Edition. Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith, *Donum Veritatis*, sections 6 to 12, on the ecclesial vocation of the theologian. John 10, for the good shepherd and the hired hand. Matthew 5:14 to 16, for the light on the lampstand, the motto of the seminary. The five dimensions are drawn from the orientation handout of the seminary.

Cross-references. This lecture seeds the sixth goal, which returns at Lecture 25, on who is a theologian, at Lecture 31, on synodality, and at Lecture 34, on the responsible theologian, before the capstone Manifesto at Lecture 35. The tension of obedience and prophecy is taken up directly at Lecture 34, again with *Donum Veritatis*.

For the professor. This lecture is the hinge of Unit I, so let it become personal. Turn the abstract question "what is a theologian" into the direct one, "what kind of theologian will you be?" Assign here the Unit I paper, "Why do I want to study theology?", five hundred words, due before Lecture 6. Tell the students plainly that this short paper is the first seed of the Manifesto they will deliver on the last day, so that they write it with care. Reading: *Donum Veritatis*, sections 6 to 12; the orientation handout on the theologian. Reflection prompt: "The kind of theologian I feel called to become is..."

CLOSING THE UNIT, AND THE BRIDGE TO UNIT II

By the end of Unit I the students should hold four convictions: that the priest cannot escape theology, only do it well or badly; that faith itself longs to understand; that we know God because he first reached down to us in revelation, received in faith; and that theology is a calling that will cost them something. The Unit I paper gathers all of this into the personal

question of vocation. Unit II now takes up the first goal head on, asking what theology is, surveying the meanings the word has carried, and drawing the line between authentic theology and its corruption. The next installment of these teaching notes will cover Unit II, Lectures 6 to 10, in the same form.

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Barrackpore, June 2026**